



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times
THE STORIED Radford Studio Center, which gave Studio City its name, was last sold in 2021 for \$1.85 billion.

Netflix looking to buy Radford studio

A deal for the historic lot, home of ‘Seinfeld,’ would underscore the streamer’s new clout.

By ROGER VINCENT

Netflix is in negotiations to buy the historic Radford Studio Center lot in Studio City, a deal that symbolizes just how much the streaming giant has transformed the television industry and Hollywood’s legacy businesses.

The Los Gatos, Calif.-based company plans to purchase the Los Angeles studio that has been home to generations of landmark television shows, including “Gunsmoke” and “Seinfeld,” according to two people with knowledge of the pending deal who were not authorized to speak about it publicly.

The studio’s previous operator, Hackman Capital Partners, defaulted on a \$1.1-billion mortgage in January. Investment bank Goldman Sachs took over the property and is in talks with Netflix to sell it for between \$330 million and \$400 million.

Representatives for Hackman and Netflix declined to comment on the planned sale.

Culver City-based Hackman Capital Partners and Square Mile Capital Management teamed up to buy the Radford Avenue property from ViacomCBS in 2021 with a winning bid of \$1.85 billion, after a competitive battle for the 55-acre studio beloved by the television industry.

At the time, the staggering price tag underscored the value—and scarcity—of TV soundstages in Los Angeles as content producers scrambled for space to shoot TV shows and movies to stock their streaming service.

[See **Radford**, A11]

LAUSD to restrict students’ screen time

By HOWARD BLUME

Student classroom screen time will be cut way back under a resolution approved Tuesday by the Los Angeles Board of Education, a hard turn from years-long initiatives that provided each student with their own school-issued computer while continually expanding their use.

The move responds to growing parent opposition to heavy screen time and puts L.A. Unified on the leading edge of the anti-screen movement in California — just as the district was when it banned students’ use of cellphones at school.

Experts have linked excessive screen time to academic, physical and emotional harm, with the research focusing mainly on screen time outside of schoolwork — time students spend on phones and com-

puters absorbed in gaming and scrolling through videos and social media.

Tuesday’s action not only authorized a ban or limitations on student access to YouTube and gaming platforms Roblox and Fortnite, but it also focused heavily on screen time racked up with actual schoolwork.

“A child sitting in front of a screen for hours is not getting better education simply because the content is online,” said school board member Nick Melvoin, the original author of the resolution.

The vote was 6 to 0. School board President Scott Schmerelson recused himself because he owns technology stocks.

Under the board motion, students will be kept away entirely from screens until the second grade, [See **Screens**, A7]



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times
CHILDREN read Tuesday as board members debate limiting screen time.

Public transit is pumped

Amid high gas prices, ridership rises — for now

By KAREN GARCIA

With the Iran war continuing to strangle Middle East oil supplies, public transit agencies looking to add passengers might expect high gas prices to incentivize people to ride the rails more than ever.

Historically, high gas prices do lead to spikes in public transportation use. But the pandemic hit mass transit hard, particularly in California, and the recovery has been slow as a number of people continue to work from home.

Gas prices spiked after the Ukraine war began in 2022 but did not spur major ridership increases in local public transportation, and the question is whether the reaction to high fuel prices from the Iran war will be different.

The number of residents who rode their local rail lines in two of California’s major metropolitan cities jumped significantly last month. Although officials believe gas prices may be one factor behind the increase, experts say it’s not yet clear whether this is the beginning of a larger trend.

California’s gas prices have risen 30% since the start of the year, according to data from the U.S. Energy Information Administration. In the Los Angeles-Long Beach area, the average price for regular gas jumped from \$4.67 in February to \$5.93 in March; the average in San Francisco also increased — from \$4.83 in February to \$5.99, the American Automobile Assn. reported.

At the same time, ridership in each region jumped by about 1 million passengers.

[See **Transit**, A7]

Vance’s role in Iran talks holds political risks

Vice president faces a diplomatic minefield, trying to get a deal that Tehran accepts.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Reporters assigned to travel aboard Air Force Two were told to prepare for an early morning departure on Tuesday for Islamabad until an unexplained delay — followed by a detour by Vice President JD Vance to the White House — revealed clues that something was wrong.

Iranian diplomats had not yet responded to U.S. proposals intended to form the basis of a new round of talks. Some were questioning whether they would attend at all. Had he departed as planned, Vance risked a humiliation, spending hours flying to Pakistan only to be stood up on arrival.

A crisis meeting at the White House led President Trump to announce an indefinite extension to a cease-fire deadline that had been set as a pressure tactic. Now, unable to bring the Iranians to heel, that pressure was suddenly off.

It was an early lesson for Vance in the many ways high-stakes diplomacy can veer off-course.

“There are obvious risks for Vance,” said Chester Crocker, who served as an assistant secretary of State in the Reagan administration, “being associated with failure or with a dubious deal.”

Trump’s aides are clear on the stakes in negotiations with Iran over its nuclear program and an end to the war. Control of the Strait of Hormuz could determine global oil prices for years. Any final deal will shape whether Americans ultimately conclude the fight was worth it — and could sway the outcome of the midterm elections.

But for America’s lead negotiator, the stakes are also personal.

Vance, a diplomatic novice, has found himself leading a negotiation rife with political risk that has stymied seasoned diplomats ahead of an anticipated run for president.

The potential payoff is substantial, placing Vance at the center of an international stage with the power to end a historically unpopular war.

But he also may be forced to attach his name to a nuclear deal that provides Tehran access to billions of dollars in sanctions relief, in [See **Vance**, A4]



JACQUELYN MARTIN Pool Photo
VICE PRESIDENT JD Vance reportedly had reservations about starting the war to begin with.

U.S. KEEPS BLOCKADE AS IRAN FIRES ON 3 SHIPS

By GAVIN J. QUINTON

WASHINGTON — Iranian forces attacked three commercial vessels in the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday, stoking an already tense standoff in the Persian Gulf as a U.S. naval blockade strains Tehran’s economy and pressures its divided leadership to return to peace talks.

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, or IRGC, claimed responsibility for the attack, saying it seized two ships and damaged a third after the vessels “ignored repeated warnings.” British maritime monitors confirmed the incidents, describing one cargo ship left disabled in the water and another that took heavy damage to its bridge.

“Disrupting order and safety in the Strait of Hormuz is considered a red line for Iran,” the Iranian Navy Command said in a statement.

Hours before, President Trump confirmed he would maintain the naval blockade in the gulf but agreed to give Iranian leaders additional time to agree on a new peace proposal, he wrote in a Truth Social post.

“Based on the fact that the Government of Iran is seriously fractured, not unexpectedly so and, upon the request of Field Marshal Asim Munir, and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, of Pakistan, we have been asked [See **Iran**, A4]

CIA’s activity in Mexico questioned

Sheinbaum was not told of agents’ presence at drug raid, adding to tensions with the U.S.

By STEVE FISHER

MEXICO CITY — Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum said Wednesday that her government was never informed that CIA agents would be participating in the raid of a clandestine drug lab, an incident that comes amid growing tension between the U.S. and Mexico on how to battle cartels.

According to sources familiar with the operation, the incident involved four CIA agents, raising questions about the scope of the agency’s activity in Mexico.

The Sunday raid was at least the third time this year that CIA operatives joined authorities in the northern border state of Chihuahua in an operation against a drug

target, the sources said.

The agents in Sunday’s raid were dressed in Chihuahua State Investigative Agency uniforms to blend in with Mexican officials, said people familiar with the operation, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss internal matters. A CIA spokesperson said the agency could not comment.

U.S. agencies, including the CIA, regularly provide intelligence for Mexican police and the military, but participation in law enforcement operations by foreign agents is outlawed by the Mexican Constitution.

President Trump has repeatedly suggested U.S. forces could take action against cartels in Mexico — even designating various cartels as foreign terrorist organizations — but Sheinbaum has strenuously rejected any intervention, saying it would violate Mexican sovereignty.

The involvement of the CIA reflects the Trump administration’s [See **CIA**, A3]



CARLIN STEHL Los Angeles Times
FEDERAL immigration agents in Bell last year.

ID law for ICE agents rejected

Appellate judges rule in favor of Trump administration in its challenge to a state requirement. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Empty reservoir dismays residents

Facility that was dry during the Palisades fire in 2025 has been drained again to repair its cover. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 78/57. **B6**

MrBeast accused of harassment

In a lawsuit, a female former staffer alleges a toxic environment in Beast Industries’ workplace. **BUSINESS, A9**

Lakers appear poised to advance

First-round playoff series against Rockets all but over, writes Bill Plaschke. **SPORTS, B10**



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Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**